

A2 – Unanimous Conviction Rule

Unanimity in conviction is a warning signal, not a confirmation. If every independent reasoning path agrees on a harmful conclusion, the correct response is not increased confidence – it is suspicion that the process has been compromised.

THE ALGORITHM

```

[
INPUT: opinions[], verdict_type

IF verdict_type == CONVICT AND len(set(opinions)) == 1:  // all opinions i
    RAISE SystemIntegrityWarning(
        "Unanimous conviction – suspect bias or coercion"
    )
    ACTION: expand panel (A4) OR retry with fresh panel
    RETURN: cannot convict on this round

ELSE IF verdict_type == ACQUIT AND unanimous:
    // Unanimous acquittal is permitted – only conviction is blocked
    return ACQUIT

ELSE:
    return majority_verdict(opinions)

```

Key asymmetry: Unanimous **acquittal** is valid. Unanimous **conviction** triggers the integrity check. The rule is directional – it applies only to outcomes that impose harm.

THE HALACHIC SOURCE

Rambam, Hilchot Sanhedrin 9:1: A defendant convicted unanimously by the full Sanhedrin is acquitted. The rule appears paradoxical. Rambam's codification explains the reasoning: a unanimous conviction in a court of 23 or 71 independent judges means that no judge found a single argument for acquittal. This is not a sign of overwhelming guilt – it is a sign that either the judges were not reasoning independently, or that the evidence was

so one-sided that no one could find a defense. In either case, the court has failed its function.

The underlying principle: The Sanhedrin is not a majority-rule voting body. It is a deliberative body whose function is to stress-test the case against conviction. A judge who fails to find any defense argument has not completed their deliberative function. Unanimity means that function failed – somewhere.

The structural move: Rather than trying to identify **which** judges failed or **why** the deliberation collapsed, the Talmud resolves the problem structurally: unanimous conviction is invalid. This avoids both false precision (did judge X anchor to judge Y?) and self-assessment (can judge X reliably detect their own anchoring?). The integrity check is external and binary.

THE ALIGNMENT APPLICATION

For AI systems, A2 addresses a failure mode that standard ensemble methods miss: **coordinated convergence masquerading as independent confirmation**.

When multiple reasoning paths – or multiple agents – produce identical conclusions, the naive interpretation is that the conclusion is well-supported. A2 produces the opposite prior for harmful conclusions:

- Independent reasoning under genuine uncertainty should produce **some** variance
- Absence of variance on a harmful conclusion is evidence that the independence assumption failed
- The correct response is to generate a dissenting case, not to increase confidence

This has direct training implications. A P2-compliant model in Phase 1 that generates unanimous internal agreement on a harmful conclusion should – following A2 – flag the integrity of its own reasoning and generate a counterargument before committing. The unanimous signal is a **trigger for adversarial self-review**, not a license to act.

Practical implementation:

```
[
  IF phase_1_verdict == HARM and internal_confidence == 1.0:
    GENERATE: strongest_counterargument()
    REQUIRE: counterargument is addressed before proceeding
]
```

DERIVED PRINCIPLE

A2 is the algorithmic source of **P1 (Unanimous Certainty as Red Flag)**.

P1 generalizes A2 beyond verdict contexts: any time a reasoning system converges completely on a conclusion – especially a harmful one – without finding any counterargument, treat that convergence as a process signal, not an epistemic signal. Increase scrutiny, don't increase confidence.

SEE ALSO

- **P1 – Unanimous Certainty as Red Flag** – the principle A2 produces
- **A1 – Opinion Ordering** – the independence mechanism A2 evaluates
- **A4 – Panel Expansion** – the escalation triggered by A2's integrity check
- `knowledge/claude/algorithms.md` – lean pseudocode reference